quote his first speech, about Pakistan taking two steps towards peace if the Indians take one step – an approach I personally believe in too) to opening the Kartarpur corridor and releasing the Indian Air Force pilot shot down by the Pakistanis in February 2019 – peaceful relations with India are essential. Both countries, even the subcontinental region, will flourish.

However, Imran Khan must do more about Kashmir. We have to resolve that issue. We have to save the Kashmiri people, and we must involve them in the peace process. Nobody in the Indian subcontinent has suffered or struggled more than Kashmiris. So much resources go into guarding this territory. So much goes into policing the Line of Control. So many mouths can get fed, so many minds can be nourished, if India and Pakistan resolve the Kashmir issue through a Kashmiri-owned, Kashmiri-led peace process.

By the way, my bit in London last year about Kashmir – I mentioned that Pakistan must first clean its house first before it tries to liberate Kashmir – was totally taken out of context. I got emotional about the issue. My timing could have been better too.

But you heard it from me: Kashmir belongs to the Kashmiris. Not to Indians. Not to Pakistanis. That debate comes later. But first and foremost, Kashmir is for the Kashmiri people themselves.

These are interesting times. Pakistan stands at the cusp of so much – internally and internationally. But the question about changing this place and turning it around haunts me. How can one be a Pakistani, especially an influential Pakistani, and not want to improve this country? How can you drive around the streets of Pakistan, see what's around you and still not want to change it?

I must say something for the record here. It might make people angry but it must be said. Whatever facilities the military gets in Pakistan, the police and other civil services must get the same. The same academies, the same training facilities, the same resources must be given to all. That's the only way the service delivery and law and order will improve in this country.

Thus, the civil–military imbalance must be fixed. The army, as the more powerful institution, must take the lead here. It must lend its best and brightest to all institutions, or it must share its best practices with others. It cannot exist in isolation. Moreover, we must all think long term – from the cricket, to peace with India, to education, to birth control and health, we must think only for the long term. Too many short-term shortcuts have been taken in this land. It's time to change that.

By the time this book is published, the Afghan peace process may have led to something. The region may have stabilized. Finally, the Americans are thinking straight, engaged in a formal peace process. If one is serious about peace in Afghanistan, one must understand that you cannot beat the Taliban. Their Pashtun blood will not let them rest. You must engage them politically. I'm glad the long war maybe, finally, coming to an end.

But Indo–Pak peace? That's a whole different argument and boils down to one man: Narendra Modi.

As long as Modi is around, I'm not sure if there will ever be peace with Pakistan. Khan sahib, clearly, is relatively more flexible than Modi ji. He has already proven this.

Also, as I've said earlier, Modi is no Vajpayee. Modi has polarized his country. I worry for India under him. But, no matter if you like him or not, peace in the region depends on Modi. He is an important man. If he does contribute to peace, there's no doubt that millions of